Participant Information Leaflet

Troublesome Technologies and Learning Trajectories in Digital Preservation Practice

Introductory statement - invitation to take part

Do you work in digital preservation—including but not limited to managing repositories, preserving complex formats, configuring metadata schemas, running integrity checks, or building automated ingest workflows? Have you encountered digital technologies or tools that were challenging to master? How did you navigate those learning hurdles, and what strategies, workarounds, or support networks did you rely on?

If so, we invite you to participate in our 9-12 minute online survey, which forms the first research strand of the study 'Troublesome Technologies and Learning Trajectories in Digital Preservation Practice'. Your insights will help us better understand how practitioners build competence as technologies, standards, and workflows evolve throughout their careers.

Taking part in this research is entirely voluntary. Please review the complete details of the Participant Information Leaflet below. If you decide to participate, click "Next" at the bottom of the page to proceed to the online informed consent declaration.

Contact Details

Dr Giulia Osti
(Research Inquiries)
School of Information and Communication Studies, University College Dublin
Email: giulia.osti@ucd.ie

Assoc. Prof. Amber Cushing
(Principal Investigator)
School of Information and Communication Studies, University College Dublin
Email: amber.cushing@ucd.ie

Title of the research

Troublesome Technologies and Learning Trajectories in Digital Preservation Practice

What is this research about? Why is this study being done?

Digital preservation involves the practices and technologies used to ensure that digital materials remain accessible and usable over time, despite technological change, media failure, organisational change, and other challenges. This research explores how digital preservation practitioners experience and navigate these learning challenges throughout their professional trajectories. In particular, the study seeks to understand what makes particular digital technologies troublesome to learn, how practitioners respond to these difficulties, what strategies and workarounds they develop, and which sources of knowledge and support they draw upon as they build competence.

The survey is the first part of a two-strand project. The second part is an optional follow-up study (comprising a written reflection submitted via an online form and, for selected participants, a short online interview). The follow-up strand is described in a separate leaflet.

Why have I been invited to take part?

You have been invited because you may have professional experience in digital preservation or a closely related area. We are seeking responses from self-identified digital preservation practitioners across differ-

ent backgrounds, workplaces, career stages, and countries. By 'digital preservation practitioner,' we mean someone who contributes to the long-term accessibility, usability, and integrity of digital materials (for example, by managing, preserving, maintaining, describing, or securing digital content, or by working with the systems, tools, standards, and workflows that support it). To take part, you should:

- Be aged 18 or over;
- Have at least one year of professional, practical experience in digital preservation or a closely related area;
- Have experience of working with digital technologies as part of your professional practice; and
- Not work/have worked exclusively in academia (that is, you should have some hands-on experience in an organisational setting).

Do I have to take part?

No. Taking part is entirely voluntary. You do not have to give a reason if you choose not to take part, and there will be no negative consequences for you if you decide not to participate.

What will happen if I decide to take part in this research study? What do I need to do?

You will complete an online survey that takes about 9-12 minutes. It runs on SurveyMonkey, and you can complete it on any web browser and device. The survey asks about your professional background, current role, work environment, career experience, learning pathways, and experiences with digital technologies that you have found challenging to learn. Some questions ask you to reflect on difficult learning experiences, and some ask for short written answers.

You choose which experience to discuss and how much detail to give. You do not need to disclose anything you consider sensitive, confidential, or identifying, and if you encounter questions you prefer not to answer, you can withdraw at any time before submitting the survey by closing your browser window.

Can I withdraw from the study? What happens if I change my mind?

You may withdraw from the survey at any time prior to submitting the form simply by closing your browser window; incomplete responses are not recorded by the survey platform.

Once submitted, fully anonymous responses cannot be identified or removed. However, if you voluntarily provide your email address to express interest in the follow-up study, your survey answers become pseudonymised. In this case, you may request the removal of your survey answers and/or withdraw your expression of interest at any time before the end of March 2027 (when the linking key is destroyed) by contacting the research team. Withdrawing will have no negative effect on you.

What are the benefits of my participation in this research: to me, to the researchers, and to any third parties involved?

Taking part in this study may not directly benefit you. Your responses will help us better understand how digital preservation practitioners learn and build competence as technologies, systems, standards, and workflows change. The research may help identify the strategies, informal learning practices, professional networks, and sources of support practitioners rely on. The outcomes of this study could benefit the wider digital preservation community, as well as educators and professional bodies that design training. The research also supports the academic work of the researchers, including scholarly publications and presentations.

What are the risks of taking part in this research study?

There are no anticipated major risks; you retain full control over what details you incorporate into your answers. Because digital preservation is a relatively small professional field, there is a minor risk that someone could recognise you from specific details in a written answer (such as an unusual job title or tool). To reduce this risk, we ask you not to include identifying details; the research team will screen all open-ended answers and de-identify them prior to analysis and publication, following our project De-identification Protocol.

How will I find out what happens with this research study?

The findings from this research study will be reported in academic publications and presented at conferences, workshops, teaching, and other research or professional events. If you would like to receive information about the outcomes of the research, you can contact the research team using the contact details provided below. No information revealing your identity will ever be disclosed in any report or publication.

Data protection

What information about me will be used in this research study?

We will use your survey responses and, if you voluntarily provide your email address to express interest in the follow-up study, that email address for research management purposes only. Your survey responses will be analysed using statistical analysis and qualitative thematic analysis to examine troublesome technology experiences in digital preservation practice. De-identified quotations and aggregated statistics may be included in academic publications and other research outputs. We will take steps to remove identifying information from material used in research outputs.

We do not intend to collect special-category personal data (such as information about your health, political opinions, or religious beliefs) as part of this study. Please avoid including such information in your responses. Technical telemetry data, such as IP addresses and location details, are disabled on the survey platform by the research team to ensure response privacy.

How will my data be used?

The information collected through this survey will be used for the purposes of this research project and to inform participant selection for the qualitative follow-up stage. Findings from the survey will be reported in academic publications, conference presentations, teaching materials, and scholarly outputs.

Raw responses collected via SurveyMonkey will be exported to and stored in the institutional cloud-based storage service (Microsoft OneDrive), protected by multi-factor authentication. Once data collection is complete, all responses will be permanently deleted from the SurveyMonkey platform. Preprocessing and initial data management will occur within UCD's Microsoft Enterprise environment, and any derivative datasets exported for statistical analysis (using software such as R or Python) will be de-identified or anonymised by default prior to analysis. Analysis files will be stored in UCD OneDrive and accessed strictly on multi-factor authenticated devices of the research team.

After publication of the research findings, the anonymised dataset may be made available to other researchers for future research related to the aims of this project, in line with UCD research data management requirements. Your email address and the link to your survey responses will never be archived or shared.

Who will have access to my personal data? What will happen to my personal data?

UCD is the data controller primarily responsible for protecting your personal data. Only the primary research team (Assoc. Prof. Amber Cushing and Dr Giulia Osti) will have access to survey responses and email contact details.

SurveyMonkey processes survey data on its EU-based servers under a formal enterprise agreement with UCD and may not use it for its own purposes. The project funder does not receive any personal or identifiable participant data. Written responses will be screened and de-identified by the research team according to the project's De-identification Protocol before data are analysed, archived, or used in outputs.

How will my personal data be protected? Will it be kept confidential?

The survey is anonymous unless you choose to give your email address. If you do not give your email address, we collect no information that identifies you. If you give your email address, it is collected in the last section of the survey and separated from your answers when the data are exported, so that it is stored apart from your survey answers.

A Participant ID (PID), assigned arbitrarily by the research team, links your email address to your survey responses. We need this link so that, if you are invited to the follow-up study, the invitation can refer to your survey answers. Until the key link is deleted, your survey responses are pseudonymised (linked to an ID, not to your name) rather than fully anonymous. The list linking PIDs to email addresses is kept in password-protected, encrypted UCD-approved cloud storage (OneDrive) accessed with multi-factor authentication, and only the Principal Investigator and Dr Osti can access it. Your email address will be kept separate from the dataset used for analysis and will not appear in the research dataset, publications, or other outputs.

How long will my data be retained by this project?

The key linking your Participant ID (PID) to your email address will be permanently deleted by the end of February 2027. The de-identified survey dataset and analysis derivatives, which contain no personal or sensitive data, will be retained for 10 years following publication or public release of the work, in line with the UCD Research Data Management Policy. Email addresses and any other personal data are not retained beyond the deletion date above.

What is the lawful basis to use my personal data?

UCD relies on the legal bases of Article 6.1(a) (Consent) and Article 6.1(e) ('Public Interest' / Public Task) of the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) to process your personal data. Should any special category (sensitive) personal data be provided accidentally in open text fields, Article 9.2(j) ('Scientific Research Purposes') applies, and the data will be redacted immediately. Giving consent for data processing under GDPR is separate from ethical consent to take part in the research.

What are my rights?

You are entitled to:

- Withdraw your consent at any time;
- Object to UCD's use of your personal data or any further use;
- Request access to your personal data and to receive a copy of it (up to the point of anonymisation);
- Request inaccurate personal data be corrected or deleted;
- Request restriction of UCD's use of your personal data (if it is inaccurate); and
- Request deletion of your data, if no longer needed.

By law, you can exercise the above rights in relation to your personal data unless certain limitations apply, for example where the request would make it impossible or very difficult to conduct the research or put the quality of the research findings at risk (such as after data have been fully anonymised or published).

Contact details

If you have questions or require reasonable accommodations/adjustments to complete the survey, please contact the research team. If any questions are not answered in a satisfactory manner, contact can be made with the UCD Data Protection Officer. Finally, if none of the UCD contacts have given a satisfactory response, you have the right to lodge a complaint with the Data Protection Commission.

- Project investigators: Dr Giulia Osti: giulia.osti@ucd.ie
- Assoc. Prof. Amber Cushing: amber.cushing@ucd.ie
- UCD Data Protection Officer (DPO): gdpr@ucd.ie
- Data Protection Commission (DPC): <https://forms.dataprotection.ie/contact>